



Anti-Catalog: 30 Heirlooms Worth Growing

Opinionated profiles of 30 varieties worth protecting

\$10

Open-pollinated • Community-grown • Food sovereignty for everyone

Anti-Catalog: 30 Heirlooms Worth Growing and Why

Seedwarden | \$10

Important Notice

This guide is educational content based on real growing experience and historical research. Your results will vary depending on your climate, soil, growing conditions, and local environment. It is not professional agricultural advice. Use it as a starting point, pay attention to what works in your specific situation, and adjust accordingly.

What Makes a Variety Worth Growing?

The seed catalogs will tell you about yield. Days to maturity. Disease resistance ratings. Whether the fruit ships well.

Here's what they usually won't tell you: that Cherokee Purple tomato tastes like something made from entirely different raw materials than a grocery-store tomato. That Dragon Tongue beans turn your dinner plate into a painting. That Fish Pepper has a history so human and specific that growing it feels like an act of remembrance.

Yield matters. It's not nothing. But if yield were all that mattered, you wouldn't be reading a guide about heirlooms. You'd be growing the most productive F1 hybrid and calling it a day.

What makes a variety worth growing, in my view:

Flavor you can't buy. Many heirlooms have been selected for taste over generations because the people growing them were also the people eating them. When the grower and the consumer are the same person, flavor wins. Commercial breeding selected for something else entirely.

A story that connects you to something larger. A pepper grown by Seminole communities for centuries. A bean that crossed the Atlantic with enslaved people. A tomato a West Virginia man used to pay off his house. These aren't just plants — they're artifacts. Growing them is a way of saying they matter.

Adaptability you can build on. Open-pollinated varieties can be saved and replanted. Over years, your saved seed becomes locally adapted to your specific conditions. That's not possible with hybrids or patented varieties. The potential to develop your own locally-adapted strain is built into every open-pollinated seed.

Biodiversity worth protecting. When a variety disappears, it's gone. The genetic material accumulated over generations — flavor compounds, disease resistance, climate adaptations — is permanently lost. Growing rare or at-risk varieties is genuinely conservation work, not just gardening.

None of this requires you to be precious about it. Grow what you like. Eat what you grow. Save what works. That's enough.

Varieties at Risk

Before the profiles, a word on what's actually at stake.

The United Nations Food and Agriculture Organization estimates that 75% of plant genetic diversity was lost in the 20th century as farmers worldwide shifted to uniform commercial varieties. This is not a number to read past quickly. Three-quarters of the food crop diversity that existed a hundred years ago is gone.

The mechanism is simple and brutal: farmers plant commercial seed, stop planting traditional varieties, the traditional varieties aren't maintained anywhere else, the seed dies with the last person who kept it.

Heirlooms genuinely at risk right now:

Mortgage Lifter (Collective Farm Woman tomato variety): Several regional strains of this once-common tomato have already been lost. The name "Mortgage Lifter" itself now refers to several distinct varieties that have been confused over decades of seed saving and sharing.

Moon and Stars Watermelon: Was considered extinct in the 1980s before a single seed keeper in Missouri was found to have maintained it. Kent Whealy of Seed Savers Exchange tracked it down and brought it back. This is not ancient history — it was 1981.

Anasazi Bean: The commercially available "Anasazi" beans are largely of uncertain provenance. The original variety grown by Ancestral Puebloans is maintained by a very small number of Indigenous growers. The genetic material from those original communities is irreplaceable.

Aunt Lou's Underground Railroad Bean: Reportedly passed down through a family connected to the Underground Railroad. Story unverified but persistent. Very few sources maintain it.

Yellow Mushroom Pepper: Documented as rare and possibly endangered by the Seed Savers Exchange. Distinct from other yellow pepper varieties.

The Seed Savers Exchange (seedsavers.org) maintains thousands of varieties donated by home gardeners. Their Heritage Farm in Iowa is one of the most important genetic repositories in North America. If you're serious about seed saving, joining is worth it.

What Makes a Good Seed Company vs. a Greenwashing One

This matters because not all seed companies are equal, and the language used to market seeds has gotten sophisticatedly misleading.

Markers of a genuinely trustworthy seed company:

Clear variety documentation: Good sources tell you where a variety came from, who maintained it, and its

history. Not "passed down through generations" but "obtained from Aunt Ruby German in 1983, from a family in Greeneville, Tennessee." Specificity is honesty.

No patents, no trademarks on plant varieties: Some companies use the marketing language of heirlooms and sustainability while actively patenting new variety developments. Check their policies.

Participation in seed saving networks: Companies that donate varieties to or cooperate with the Seed Savers Exchange, regional seed libraries, or Indigenous seed keeping organizations are putting resources behind the values they espouse.

Honest about growing conditions: Good catalogs tell you what a variety struggles with, not just where it excels.

Signatories to the Safe Seed Pledge: This pledge commits companies not to sell GMO seeds. It's a low bar but a meaningful signal.

Red flags:

Patented or trademarked varieties sold alongside marketing about "open-pollinated" values: These aren't compatible positions. Ask which varieties are which.

Extremely polished marketing with vague provenance: Scale and polish aren't bad things, but when the story behind a variety is "this classic heirloom has been loved for generations" without specifics, be skeptical.

No indication of where seeds are grown or by whom: Some companies source from large seed production operations while maintaining artisanal branding.

Dismissiveness toward questions: Good seed companies answer questions about provenance and practices. Poor ones deflect.

Companies with strong reputations (as of writing): Seed Savers Exchange, Baker Creek Heirloom Seeds, Southern Exposure Seed Exchange, Native Seeds/SEARCH (specializing in Southwestern varieties), Fedco Seeds, High Mowing Organic Seeds, Adaptive Seeds, Uprising Seeds. This list isn't exhaustive and isn't an endorsement — do your own research and ask questions.

The 30 Varieties

Tomatoes

1. Cherokee Purple

Lycopersicon esculentum

Origin: Tennessee. Named for the Cherokee Nation, though the specific history is disputed — it may have been grown in Cherokee communities for generations, or the name may be more recent attribution. What isn't disputed: it arrived in modern seed-saving networks through Craig LeHoullier, who received it in 1990 from a Tennessee family who'd grown it for over a century.

What it looks like: Large, irregular beefsteak. The shoulders are deep purple-green; the interior is brick-red and dusky. It looks bruised. It is not bruised.

Flavor: This is the tomato that converts people. Rich, complex, sweet-acidic in deep balance, with a wine-like quality unlike anything bred for shipping. The flavor is specific and unmistakable.

Why it's worth preserving: Represents a flavor profile in danger of being forgotten — what tomatoes actually tasted like before sweetness and shelf life became the only metrics.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Baker Creek, Seed Savers Exchange, widely available

2. Brandywine (Sudduth strain)

Lycopersicon esculentum

Origin: Pennsylvania. The Sudduth strain is the one most people mean when they say "Brandywine." Traced to Dorris Sudduth Hill of West Virginia, who received it from relatives whose family had grown it since the 1880s. Amish farmers in Ohio and Pennsylvania maintained similar strains.

What it looks like: Large pink beefsteak, irregular, potato-leaved plant (the leaves look different from typical tomato foliage). Fruits crack easily and don't ship well. Irrelevant.

Flavor: Probably the most referenced flavor standard in heirloom tomatoes. Rich, complex, low-acid sweetness. Most years, most people who taste it say it's the best tomato they've ever had.

Why it's worth preserving: It is the gold standard. If heirlooms have a flagship, this is it.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Everywhere. Choose Sudduth strain specifically.

3. Mortgage Lifter

Lycopersicon esculentum

Origin: Logan, West Virginia. Developed by Radiator Charlie (M.C. Byles) in the 1930s by crossing four large-fruited varieties over six years. He sold starts at \$1 each and paid off his \$6,000 mortgage in six years. The whole thing is extraordinary.

What it looks like: Very large pink-red beefsteak. Often 1–2 pounds. Meaty, few seeds.

Flavor: Sweet, mild, low-acid. One of the most pleasant eating tomatoes, not the most complex but deeply satisfying.

Why it's worth preserving: The story is part of the variety. A working man bred a tomato in the Depression using his own ingenuity and persistence, and that variety has now been in continuous cultivation for 90 years.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Baker Creek, Seed Savers Exchange

4. Green Zebra

Lycopersicon esculentum

Origin: Developed by Tom Wagner in 1983 — technically newer than many heirlooms, but fully open-pollinated and now widely maintained. Wagner is a notable figure in independent tomato breeding.

What it looks like: Small to medium (2–4 oz). Yellow-green with darker green stripes at maturity. The stripes deepen from lime to forest green.

Flavor: Bright, sharp, acidic, distinctly zingy. A completely different flavor profile than red tomatoes.

Why it's worth preserving: Represents the genetic possibility of tomatoes beyond the red-sweet paradigm. The flavor profile is irreplaceable in a summer salad.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Widely available

5. Amish Paste

Lycopersicon esculentum

Origin: Wisconsin Amish communities.

What it looks like: Large elongated paste tomato, 6–8 oz, oxheart-shaped. Meaty, few seeds, thick walls.

Flavor: Rich, sweet, intensely tomato. The best sauce tomato on this list.

Why it's worth preserving: Sauce tomatoes tend to get bred for yield and processing efficiency. This one was bred for eating. The flavor difference in a batch of canned sauce is noticeable.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Seed Savers Exchange, Baker Creek

Peppers

6. Fish Pepper

Capsicum annuum

Origin: African-American culinary tradition, primarily in the Chesapeake Bay region. Used in Baltimore fish houses and oyster establishments in the 19th and early 20th centuries. Nearly lost; reintroduced to broader cultivation by Seed Savers Exchange after being maintained by a single family.

What it looks like: Fruits start cream-white with green stripes, mature to orange-red. Striking at every stage.

Flavor: Medium heat, fruity, complex. The fresh sauce made from white-stage fish peppers is unlike anything else.

Why it's worth preserving: The variety encodes a specific culinary tradition from African-American community life. Growing it is a direct connection to that history.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Seed Savers Exchange, Southern Exposure Seed Exchange

7. Lemon Drop (*Aji Limo*)

Capsicum baccatum

Origin: Peru. A staple of Peruvian cuisine, part of the *baccatum* species group.

What it looks like: Small, elongated, bright yellow fruits. Compact plant.

Flavor: Fruity, intensely citrusy, bright heat. Tastes like there's lemon juice in the pepper when there isn't.

Why it's worth preserving: The *baccatum* flavor profile is categorically different from *annuum* peppers. This is the most accessible entry point to it.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Baker Creek, Seed Savers Exchange

8. Chimayo

Capsicum annuum

Origin: Chimayo, New Mexico. Grown for centuries in the high-desert villages of northern New Mexico. The specific regional conditions (altitude, soil, climate) produce a chile with a flavor that can't quite be replicated elsewhere.

What it looks like: Long, red, slightly wrinkled fruits. Grown traditionally for drying.

Flavor: Earthy, sweet, moderately hot. The classic New Mexico red chile flavor.

Why it's worth preserving: This is one of the clearest examples of terroir in a vegetable variety — the flavor is inseparable from where it's grown. Growing it elsewhere is still worthwhile, but understanding that

connection deepens appreciation for place-based seed saving.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Native Seeds/SEARCH

Beans

9. Dragon Tongue

Phaseolus vulgaris

Origin: Netherlands. An old Dutch variety.

What it looks like: Yellow pods with vivid purple streaks. Purple fades to yellow-green when cooked. Eat them raw.

Flavor: Buttery, mild, better raw than cooked.

Why it's worth preserving: Beauty has value. A plate of raw Dragon Tongue beans is an argument for growing food yourself that a grocery store can't make.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Widely available

10. Rattlesnake Pole Bean

Phaseolus vulgaris

Origin: Disputed — various Southern U.S. origins cited, possibly Cherokee.

What it looks like: Long green pods with purple striping. Vigorous vines to 8–10 feet.

Flavor: Rich, slightly nutty as a snap bean; excellent dried.

Why it's worth preserving: Both the visual drama and the dual-use nature (snap bean and dry bean from one variety) make this one of the most practical heirloom beans available.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Baker Creek, widely available

11. Jacob's Cattle Bean

Phaseolus vulgaris

Origin: Maine. Brought to the region by the Passamaquoddy people. One of the oldest documented beans in continuous cultivation in North America.

What it looks like: Red-and-white marbled bean with a distinctive pattern.

Flavor: Creamy, earthy, excellent baked beans.

Why it's worth preserving: The Indigenous origin and continuous cultivation history make this one of the most meaningful beans to maintain. It's also genuinely delicious.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Fedco, Seed Savers Exchange

12. Calypso (Yin Yang Bean)

Phaseolus vulgaris

Origin: Central America.

What it looks like: Black-and-white marbled seeds, precise enough to look painted.

Flavor: Creamy when cooked, mild, holds shape well.

Why it's worth preserving: The visual perfection of the seed deserves preservation on aesthetic grounds alone. It also cooks beautifully.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Seed Savers Exchange, Southern Exposure

Greens

13. Forellenschluss Lettuce

Lactuca sativa

Origin: Austria. The name means "trout's back" — referring to the red speckles on green leaves.

What it looks like: Loose butterhead, green with burgundy spots. One of the most beautiful vegetables available.

Flavor: Buttery, mild, tender. Outstanding lettuce.

Why it's worth preserving: In a world that thinks lettuce comes in four varieties (iceberg, romaine, spring mix, arugula), Forellenschluss is a visual and gustatory argument for more.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Baker Creek, Seed Savers Exchange

14. Malabar Spinach

Basella alba

Origin: South and Southeast Asia. Widely used in tropical cuisines.

What it looks like: Lush, glossy, succulent leaves on vigorous vines. Striking plant.

Flavor: Mild, slightly mucilaginous when cooked, completely pleasant.

Why it's worth preserving: Extends the "spinach" season deep into summer when real spinach bolts. Represents a culinary tradition that most Western gardeners haven't encountered.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Baker Creek

15. Bloomsdale Spinach

Spinacia oleracea

Origin: 19th century American breeding. One of the oldest named American vegetable varieties still in common cultivation.

What it looks like: Deep-green, heavily savoyed (crinkled) leaves.

Flavor: Rich, sweet, intensely spinach. Noticeably better than flat-leaf commercial varieties.

Why it's worth preserving: The flavor is the reason. This is what spinach is supposed to taste like.

Seed saving difficulty: Medium (spinach is wind-pollinated and dioecious)

Where to find seeds: Widely available

16. Lacinato Kale (Dinosaur Kale)

Brassica oleracea

Origin: Italy. Associated particularly with Tuscany; documented in Italian cultivation since at least the 18th century.

What it looks like: Dark blue-green, heavily textured, almost pebbly leaves on tall plants.

Flavor: Rich, sweet after frost, less bitter than curly kale. The standard for braised kale.

Why it's worth preserving: The flavor improvement with cold (which triggers sugar production) is one of the most rewarding late-season garden experiences. A late-fall harvest of Lacinato is one of the best things a container garden can produce.

Seed saving difficulty: Medium

Where to find seeds: Everywhere

Roots

17. Chioggia Beet

Beta vulgaris

Origin: Chioggia, Italy. A fishing village near Venice; the beet bears the town's name.

What it looks like: Red exterior, interior rings alternate pink and white — like a candy cane. The striping is vivid raw, fades when cooked.

Flavor: Sweeter and earthier than commercial beets, less intensely earthy than Detroit Red types.

Why it's worth preserving: The striping alone is worth it. Slice raw into a salad and watch people stop talking.

Seed saving difficulty: Medium (biennial, crosses with chard)

Where to find seeds: Widely available

18. Watermelon Radish

Raphanus sativus

Origin: China (daikon family). A Chinese heirloom brought to the U.S. by Chinese immigrants.

What it looks like: Plain green exterior. Slice it open: vivid magenta-pink interior fading to white near the skin.

Flavor: Mild when small, peppery when large. Best raw.

Why it's worth preserving: Another argument for eating your own vegetables — the interior of a watermelon radish is genuinely beautiful, and you never see the interior in a grocery store.

Seed saving difficulty: Medium

Where to find seeds: Baker Creek, widely available

19. Atomic Red Carrot

Daucus carota

Origin: Modern open-pollinated development; not a traditional heirloom but fully open-pollinated.

What it looks like: Deep red exterior and interior, color intensifies when cooked.

Flavor: Mildly sweet, earthier than orange carrots. The red color comes from lycopene (same compound as red tomatoes).

Why it's worth preserving: Represents the breadth of what "carrot" can be. Orange carrots became standard in Western markets through specific 17th-century Dutch breeding; it's a choice, not a natural law.

Seed saving difficulty: Medium

Where to find seeds: Baker Creek, Seed Savers Exchange

20. Parsnip (The Student)

Pastinaca sativa

Origin: England. Developed at the Royal Horticultural Society in the 1840s. One of the most important heirloom parsnip varieties.

What it looks like: Long, white-cream roots. Classic parsnip.

Flavor: Sweet, nutty, distinctly parsnip. Outstanding roasted.

Why it's worth preserving: Parsnips are one of the most underrated winter vegetables in North American cooking. This variety represents the flavor standard.

Seed saving difficulty: Medium (biennial, cross-pollinates with wild parsnip)

Where to find seeds: Fedco, Baker Creek

Cucurbits

21. Delicata Squash

Cucurbita pepo

Origin: New York, late 19th century. Widely grown, then nearly disappeared from commercial cultivation, then resurrected by specialty seed companies.

What it looks like: Cream-colored oblong squash with green-orange stripes. Small enough to eat whole.

Flavor: Sweet, nutty, almost dessert-like. Thin skin is edible.

Why it's worth preserving: The flavor is the reason winter squash exists. Better than butternut for straight eating; easier to prepare because of the thin edible skin.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Widely available

22. Moon and Stars Watermelon

Citrullus lanatus

Origin: Lost and found. Grown in the late 1800s and early 1900s, then disappeared from catalogues. Considered extinct. Rediscovered in 1981 in Missouri by Seed Savers Exchange founder Kent Whealy.

What it looks like: Dark green rind with yellow spots — one large "moon" and many small "stars." The pattern is striking.

Flavor: Sweet, classic red-fleshed watermelon. Excellent flavor.

Why it's worth preserving: The fact that this variety was lost, found by one man, and brought back by seed savers is one of the great stories in American seed saving. Growing it is a participation in that story.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Baker Creek, Seed Savers Exchange

23. Spacemaster Cucumber

Cucumis sativus

Origin: New Hampshire, 1960s. Bred by the University of New Hampshire for small spaces.

What it looks like: Standard slicing cucumber, compact bush plant.

Flavor: Classic mild cucumber.

Why it's worth preserving: This is the variety that makes cucumber-growing accessible to apartment gardeners. The breeding intention — specifically designed for limited space — is worth honoring.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Widely available

Herbs

24. Genovese Basil

Ocimum basilicum

Origin: Liguria, Italy. The basil of Italian cuisine, specifically the variety used in traditional pesto genovese.

What it looks like: Large, cupped, intensely green leaves.

Flavor: Intensely aromatic, clove-pepper-anise. The canonical basil flavor.

Why it's worth preserving: Grocery-store basil is typically a different variety bred for shelf life. The flavor difference is immediately apparent.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Widely available

25. Epazote

Dysphania ambrosioides

Origin: Mexico and Central America. Used in Mesoamerican cooking for thousands of years. A pre-Columbian herb.

What it looks like: Jagged, pungent, somewhat weedy-looking plant.

Flavor: Strong, petroleum-like, complex. Essential in black beans, corn tortillas, and Mexican cooking. Polarizing for those not raised with it.

Why it's worth preserving: The herb encodes a specific culinary tradition thousands of years old. Its pungency is also genuinely useful — epazote reduces the gas-producing properties of beans when cooked with them.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy (self-seeds aggressively — be warned)

Where to find seeds: Native Seeds/SEARCH, Baker Creek

26. Shiso (Red/Perilla)

Perilla frutescens

Origin: East and Southeast Asia. Used in Japanese, Korean, and Vietnamese cuisines.

What it looks like: Large, ruffled, deep purple leaves with jagged edges. Stunning plant.

Flavor: Complex — mint, basil, anise, citrus. There's nothing quite like it.

Why it's worth preserving: Represents a culinary tradition underrepresented in Western seed catalogs.

Beautiful, highly productive, and essentially impossible to find fresh outside of Asian grocery stores in most cities.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Baker Creek, Kitazawa Seed Company

27. Lemon Balm

Melissa officinalis

Origin: Southern Europe and the Mediterranean. In cultivation for at least 2,000 years.

What it looks like: Small, heavily textured leaves. Vigorous, somewhat spreading.

Flavor: Bright lemon, fresh, clean. Tea herb, culinary herb, cocktail herb.

Why it's worth preserving: One of the most versatile herbs in existence, and one of the easiest to grow. Comes back year after year. A plant worth establishing and keeping.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Widely available

Additional Varieties Worth Knowing

28. Seminole Pumpkin

Cucurbita moschata

Origin: Florida Everglades, Seminole people. Grown for centuries in subtropical conditions. Heat-tolerant, humidity-tolerant, resistant to squash vine borer.

Flavor: Rich and sweet, like butternut but with more character.

Why it's worth preserving: The variety's resistance traits are the product of centuries of selection in a specific difficult environment. That genetic information is irreplaceable.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Baker Creek, Native Seeds/SEARCH

29. Anasazi Bean

Phaseolus vulgaris

Origin: Ancestral Puebloans of the American Southwest. Documented in archaeological sites more than 1,500 years old.

What it looks like: Red-and-white mottled pattern.

Flavor: Earthy, slightly sweet, creamy. Cooks faster than many beans (lower phytic acid).

Why it's worth preserving: Among the oldest cultivated beans in North America. The varieties maintained by Indigenous communities today carry centuries of breeding information. Most commercially available "Anasazi" beans are of uncertain provenance — seek out Native-grown sources when possible.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Native Seeds/SEARCH

30. Jimmy Nardello Pepper

Capsicum annuum

Origin: Ruoti, southern Italy, brought to the United States in 1887 by the Nardello family when they immigrated from Basilicata. Giuseppe Nardello preserved the seeds; his son Jimmy grew it throughout his life in Connecticut. After Jimmy's death, his wife saved seeds and donated them to Seed Savers Exchange.

What it looks like: Long, thin, sweet frying pepper. Bright red at full ripeness.

Flavor: Sweet, rich, complex — caramelizes beautifully when fried. Not at all like a bell pepper.

Why it's worth preserving: The story is a complete arc — an immigrant family's food culture crossing an ocean, a son's lifetime of cultivation, a widow's decision to donate seeds rather than let the variety die with her husband. The pepper is delicious. The story is worth honoring.

Seed saving difficulty: Easy

Where to find seeds: Seed Savers Exchange, Baker Creek; a Slow Food Ark of Taste member

Where to Start

Thirty varieties is overwhelming. If you're starting fresh, pick two or three.

Pick something with a story that resonates. Pick something you want to eat. Pick something that fits your growing conditions honestly.

Grow it well. Save the seed. Grow it again.

That's the whole thing.

Seedwarden | Not a catalog. An argument.

Grow what matters.

More from Seedwarden

If you found this guide useful, you might also like:

- Heirloom Variety Selection Guide (\$11) — Match varieties to your exact soil, climate, and light conditions
- Seed Saving Field Manual (\$14) — Save seed from every variety in this catalog so you never reorder
- Food Sovereignty Starter Guide (\$8) — The complete beginner roadmap for growing and sharing your own food

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